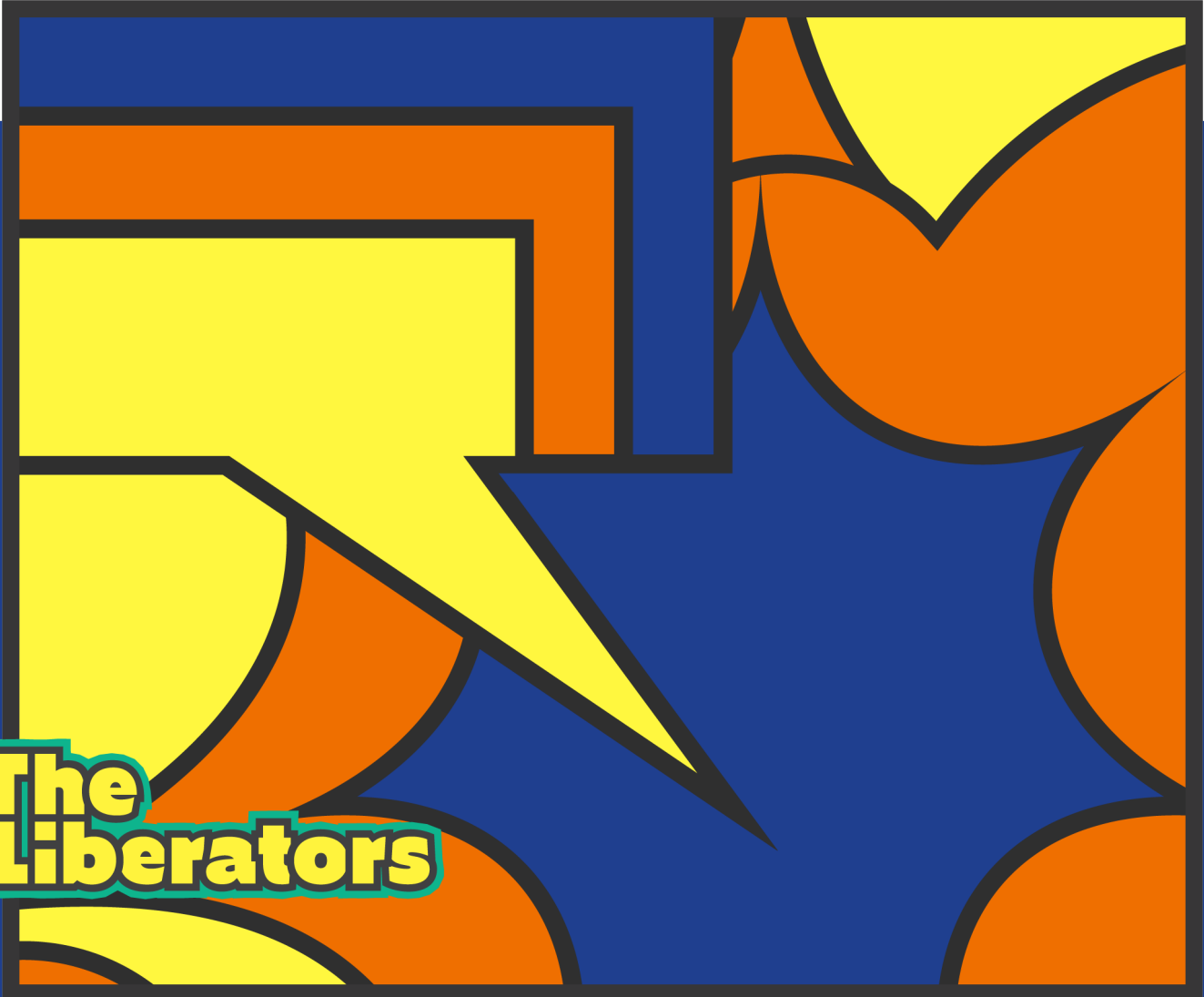


Amplify Learning In Your Team With More Double-Loop Learning

A do-it-yourself workshop to invest in the factors that contribute to deep, double-loop learning in your team and organization



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

Do you remember the first few weeks of your first professional job? It's entirely likely that you were struck by weird rules, awkward procedures, and illogical ways of working. But like most of us, you probably started excepting that as "the way we do things here" after a while, without second-guessing it.

This is a simple illustration of single- and double-loop learning as defined by the organizational theorist Chris Argyris. It is an important part of our book the ["Zombie Scrum Survival Guide"](#). Single-loop learning focuses on solving a problem within an existing system that is defined

by sets of beliefs, structures, roles, procedures, and norms. Double-loop learning challenges the system, and underlying beliefs themselves. But unfortunately, as our experience grows, we are often increasingly blinded by it to see new options.

Although both types of learning are important for continuous improvement to happen, double-loop learning is important in particular for complex work where teams have to constantly challenge not only how they do the work, but also why. Teams affected by Zombie Scrum tend to limit themselves to single-loop learning and can't benefit from double-loop learning because their existing beliefs about management, products, how to manage people, and how to manage risk remain unchallenged.

We created this do-it-yourself workshop to make your team aware of how different levels of learning are possible. And to help your team learn more effectively by using double-loop learning to challenge their existing ways of working and the system in which that works takes place.

Why don't you use your next Sprint Retrospective to improve how you learn? Give it a try, and let us know the results!

Let's learn and grow, together!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Flow

Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Explore How To Guarantee Shallow Learning With "Impromptu Networking"

  20 min

Step 3: Explain The Concept Of Single- And Double-Loop Learning

 15 min

Step 4: Explore What Contributes To Double-Loop Learning With "Conversation Cafe"

  40 min

Step 5: Invest In Double-Loop Learning In Your Team With "15% Solutions"

  10 min

Step 6: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 90 min

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



The structures in the workshop are easy to facilitate. The invitations can trigger intense conversations, so keep an eye on the timeboxes.

Impact On Survival



A team that learns how to effectively challenge existing rules and beliefs can create an environment in which they can flourish.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one Scrum team that wants to improve how they learn. But the steps also work really well with more Scrum teams. This might help to spot patterns and resolve deeper impediments that prevent continuous improvement.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Blog post: [Myth: In Scrum, we spend too much time in meetings](#)
- Podcast: [Why Scrum Teams Struggle To Improve Continuously](#)



3 min

Step 1: Opening



Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.





Step 2: Explore How To Guarantee Shallow Learning With "Impromptu Networking"



The start of this workshop is intended to help your team start their thinking about different levels of learning. Most likely, they can use these ideas as inspiration for later moments in the workshop. Use the Liberating Structure [Impromptu Networking](#) to rapidly gain and share these ideas.

Invitation

"What can you personally do to guarantee that your own learning, and that of your team, remains shallow and never goes to the root of a problem?"

Steps

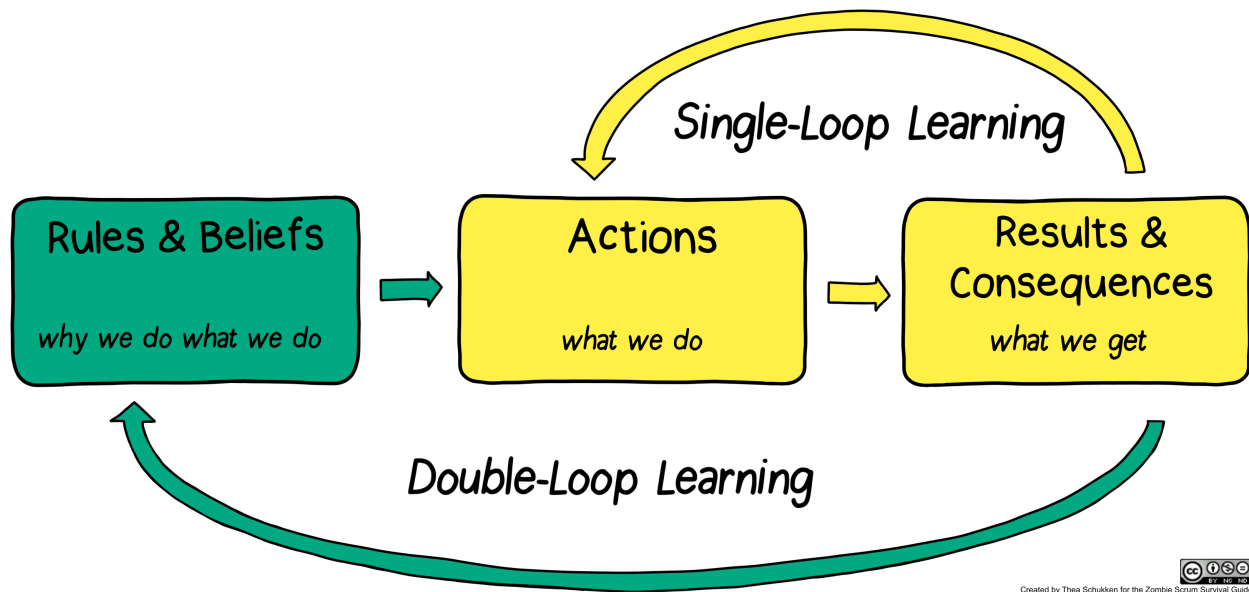
1. **1 min** First offer the invitation and give everyone a minute to silently get their thinking started about what comes to mind.
2. **3 min** Ask everyone to form pairs and let them share their ideas and thoughts with their partner. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms.
3. **6 min** Repeat the previous round twice more. Invite people into new pairs, and let them share their thoughts and observations while noticing patterns.
4. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask the participants for the patterns they noticed. Capture them on a shared surface if you want to.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Rapidly share novel ideas and make personal connections with 'Impromptu Networking'](#)



Step 3: Explain The Concept Of Single- And Double-Loop Learning



Source: Argyris, C. On Organizational Learning, Cambridge, MA: Blackwell, 1993

Created by Thies Schükken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christian Vorwies, Johannes Schenk & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

In the previous step, you used Impromptu Networking to explore what shallow learning looks like. In this step, your team reflects on how they use single- and double-loop learning to improve themselves and their environment. If the team isn't aware of this concept yet, it's helpful to give a short explanation. You can use parts of the text below to prepare a short teaching moment. Whatever approach you use: keep it short and concise. With a few tangible examples, people will quickly understand the most important parts of the model.

Steps

- **5 min** Explain the basics of single- and double-loop learning
- **2 min** Ask "What is something that needs clarification before we continue with the workshop?". Give the team time to formulate their questions.
- **8 min** Answer the most urgent questions, point to the resources we share in this workshop for future research.

On Organizational Learning

When teams don't get value anymore from their Sprint Retrospectives, this could be because of how they learn. While it's essential, teams and organizations are not always aware of how learning takes place. In our book the [Zombie Scrum Survival Guide](#), we included the concept of single- and double-loop learning. It's based on the book [On Organizational Learning](#) by Chris Argyris.



Single- And Double-Loop Learning

Single-loop learning focuses on solving a problem within an existing system that is defined by sets of beliefs, structures, roles, procedures, and norms. Double-loop learning challenges the system itself. As an example of single-loop learning, a Scrum Team might explore different techniques for estimating their Product Backlog for the purpose of forecasting. The Scrum Team might also use double-loop learning to challenge the purpose of forecasting itself and look for other ways to satisfy the need to forecast. Another example of single-loop learning is when developers try to fix broken unit tests faster, whereas double-loop learning would see them question why their unit tests are so prone to breaking in the first place. A final example of single-loop learning is when a Product Owner tries to better capture requirements on the Product Backlog, whereas double-loop learning might make her question the need for detailed requirements in an empirical process in the first place.

So where single-loop learning improves what is possible within the current system, double-loop learning is about challenging and changing the system. Double-loop learning helps people change (sometimes deeply held) assumptions and beliefs.

"Single-loop learning focuses on solving a problem within an existing system that is defined by sets of beliefs, structures, roles, procedures, and norms. Double-loop learning challenges the system itself."

Why Organizations Struggle

Although both types of learning are important for continuous improvement to happen, Argyris emphasizes double-loop learning as particularly important for non-routine, complex work where teams have to constantly challenge not only how they do the work, but also why. The many changes that organizations have to go through to transition from plan-based approaches to empirical ways of working mean that organizations need to employ a high degree of double-loop learning to change underlying beliefs about risk, control, management, and professionalism. Organizations that find themselves unable to change the rules, norms, and beliefs that stand in their way will struggle to stay competitive.

The Blindness of Experience

Unfortunately, Argyris also notes that highly-trained professionals in particular often struggle to practice double-loop learning, as it involves challenging the practices and skills that have made them successful in the past.





Step 4: Explore What Contributes To Double-Loop Learning With "Conversation Café"



So far, the team explored what shallow learning looks like, and how it contrasts to the deeper learning of double-loop learning. In this step, you invite the team to share personal stories and experiences with double-loop learning, and what contributed to making it possible. To share personal stories, the Liberating Structure [Conversation Café](#) is ideally suited. In small groups, everyone has the opportunity to share personal challenges and to learn from the experiences of others.

Invitation

"When did you, or this team, experience a moment of double-loop learning where the existing system was challenged and then changed? What seems to be important about creating an environment where this deep learning is possible?"

Steps

1. If you do this in person, ask people to form groups of 4 or 5 people. When done virtually, prepare breakouts.
2. **2 min** Share the invitation for Conversation Café and give everyone some time to individually and silently reflect.
3. **2 min** Provide a rough overview of the rounds. Each group goes through four rounds, two first rounds with a talking object, the third one as an open conversation, and a final round to share personal insights again.
4. **2 min** Explain that, once everyone is in their small groups, they will self-manage the rounds. Ask for each group to pick a host. The host is a full participant whose role is to keep the timeboxes and to gently intervene when a participant fails to observe the timebox or is talking on and on.
5. **5 min** In the first round, everyone shares their personal thoughts and experience with regard to the selected invitation. Emphasize that this round is *not* a conversation.
6. **5 min** In the second round, everyone shares thoughts and feelings after having listened to everybody. Emphasize that this round is *not* a conversation.
7. **8 min** The third round is an open and lively conversation.
8. **5 min** In the fourth round, everyone shares their takeaways from the conversation. People have the option to pass.
9. **5 min** Briefly discuss the patterns that emerged with the entire group.

Our Findings

- It's helpful to keep the visual with all the steps visible while everyone is in the breakout rooms. You can prepare a Mural or Google Presentation that contains all the steps.
- Emphasize that groups should use talking objects. Participants can use whatever they prefer as a talking object, as long as they have one. A pen or marker that participants "pass around" is a fun way of using a talking object online. A good practice is that the person holding the talking object decides who goes next.
- Encourage people to really listen. In the first two rounds and in the final round, the purpose is not to have a discussion, to ask each other questions, or to start a conversation. The purpose is only for each participant to share their perspectives while the others offer their full attention.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- The [article](#) we wrote about Conversation Café





Conversation Café

We agree to ...

1. Suspend judgement
2. Respect one another
3. Seek to understand rather than persuade
4. Invite and honor diverse opinions
5. Speak what has personal heart and meaning
6. Go for honesty and depth without going on and on and on and on ...

Decide who volunteers as a host. The host fully participates, and gently intervenes where necessary to protect the agreements and timeboxes.

1

Everyone takes 1 minute to share their reflections and thoughts on the topic. Only the person with the talking object speaks, and this person decides who gets it next. People may skip a turn.

2

Everyone takes 1 minute to share their reflections and observations on the first round. Only the person with the talking object speaks, and this person decides who gets it next. People may skip a turn.

3

As a group, engage in open, lively conversation about the topic. If you want, you can continue to use the talking object (10-30 min).

4

Everyone takes 1 minute to share their takeaways from the conversation. Only the person with the talking object speaks, and this person decides who goes next. People may skip a turn.

The Liberators

Developed by Keith McCandless & Henri Lipmanowicz.

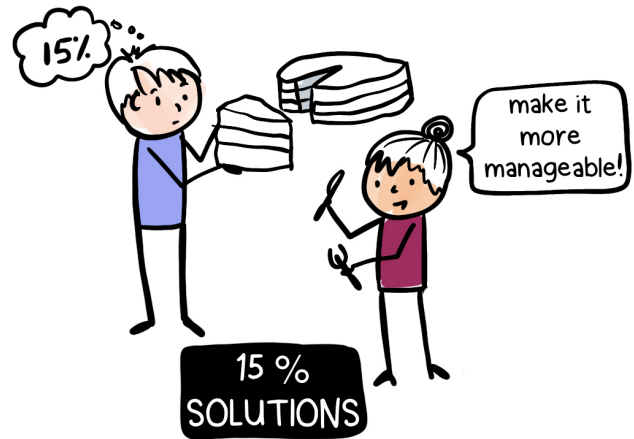
shop.theliberators.com



Step 5: Invest In Double-Loop Learning In Your Team With "15% Solutions"

In this workshop, your team explored the difference between single- and double-loop learning. Even though everybody probably sees the value of double-loop learning, it is also true that this is difficult to do in practice. Unfortunately, people with more experience tend to struggle more here as their experience blinds them to seeing new options.

In this final step, you invite your team to identify small first steps they can all take to create an environment where double-loop learning is more likely to happen. We use the Liberating Structure [15% Solutions](#) here with keeps improvements both small and personal.



Invitation

"What is your 15% Solution for investing in one of the factors we identified during the Conversation Cafe?
How can you challenge the system more effectively?"

Steps

1. **3 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partner find a way to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).
3. **2 min** When everyone is together, ask people to add their 15% Solutions to a shared workspace and briefly mention what they intend to do. You can keep these 15% Solutions transparent by adding them to the Sprint Backlog, or the Product Backlog for future Sprints.

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?".

Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)

Step 6: Closing

With this workshop, you helped the team learn more about single- and double-loop learning, and how they can use it to spur continuous improvement by challenging existing rules and beliefs.

If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!

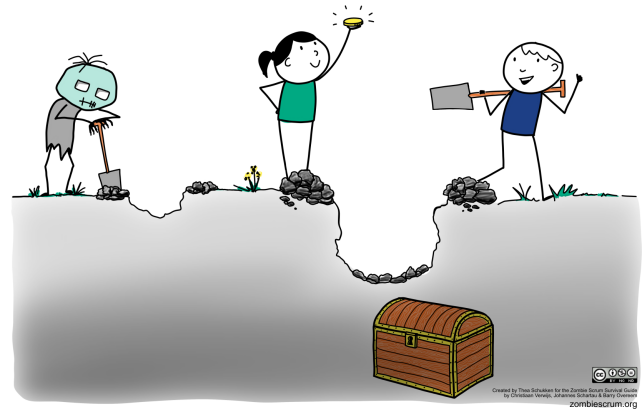


10 Other Experiments To Help Your Team Improve Continuously

In our book, the [Zombie Scrum Survival Guide](#), we offer 10 experiments to help your team improve continuously. Check the book for all the details. So don't worry if your team or organization hasn't fully embraced a learning culture. There are enough experiments available to help you improve the situation! Some experiments offer inspiration on how to run a Sprint Retrospective differently. Others take continuous improvement to the organizational level.

Share An Impediment Newsletter Throughout the Organization

The impediments that make it hard for Scrum Teams to work empirically often involve people across the organization. Helping these people understand the impediments, and the problems they cause creates awareness that enables double-loop learning, which can lead to systemic improvements.



Ask Powerful Questions During Sprint Retrospectives

People's deeply held beliefs, assumptions, and values influence how successful they will be in changing. Many of these assumptions are subconscious and need to be surfaced in order to be challenged. This experiment is designed to help teams by asking powerful questions to do so.

Dig Deeper into Problems and Potential Solutions, Together

Effectively analyzing and removing impediments is important for deep learning and continuous improvement. Teams have to learn how to ask or write questions that include different perspectives, and to identify specific and actionable solutions. The Liberating Structure "Discovery and Action Dialogue" is ideal for this exploration, it's explained in this experiment.

Create 15% Solutions

Continuous improvement works best when changes are small and start from what people can change on their own. To help with this, the organizational theorist Gareth Morgan proposed the concept of "15% Solutions". This experiment helps your Scrum Team define 15% Solutions and create change even in environments where little seems possible.

Focus On What To Stop Doing

Instead of adding more things to do, find things that you are doing that are unproductive and eliminate them. The Liberating Structure "TRIZ" is of huge help, as it invites creative destruction of activities that limit innovation and productivity by engaging everyone in a playful way.

Create Improvement Recipes

Vague improvement ideas like "More collaboration" or "Use Sprint Goals", or ideas that have no clear start and end, won't propel teams forward. This experiment is about translating vague improvements into something specific by building on each other's intelligence and creativity.

Use Formal and Informal Networks to Drive Change

Changing the environment of Scrum Teams can be difficult when you're trying to do it alone. This experiment is about leveraging the informal and formal networks in organizations to create change, together. It is based on the Liberating Structures "Social Network Webbing".

Create a Low-Tech Metrics Dashboard to Track Outcomes

How well is your team performing? Do you know what outcomes you're delivering? More often than not, teams try to answer these questions by tracking velocity or the number of items completed per Sprint. Although this tells you how busy you are, it doesn't tell you how useful that work actually is. In this experiment, we outline the steps for helping teams to select their own metrics.

Share Success Stories and Build on What Made Them Possible

Instead of focusing on the things that don't go well – as is all too easy in Zombie Scrum – you can help teams focus on what is already working and improve from there. Sharing successful experiences, stories, and strategies from the past is a good way to both build safety and uncover unseen paths forward. This experiment is based on the Liberating Structure "Appreciative Interviews".

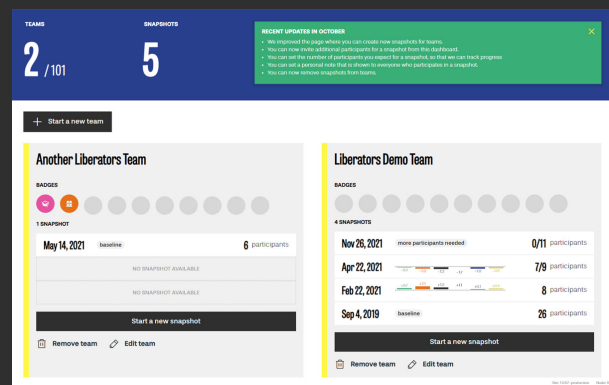
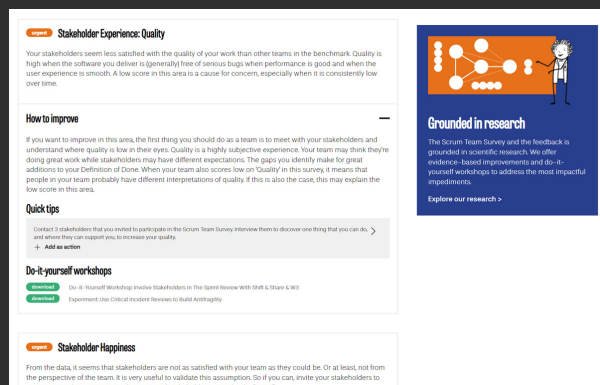
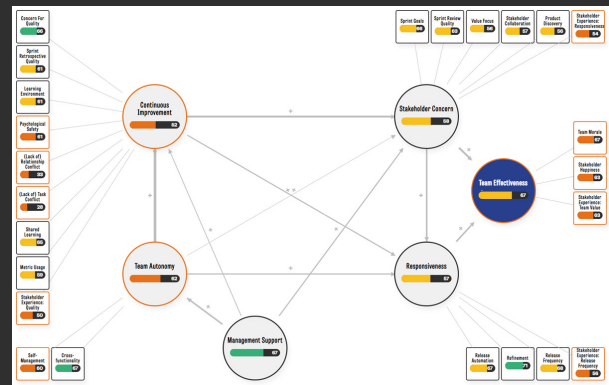
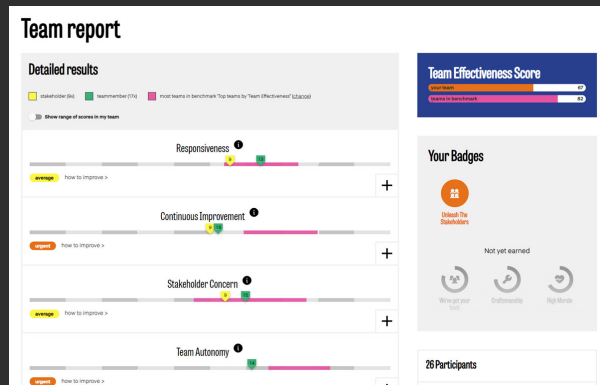
Bake a Release Pie

A great way to build team spirit is to acknowledge small successes as they happen. For example, teams can celebrate every time they release to production, or when they automate another part that would require manual work otherwise. We've found it helpful to celebrate these successes in a simple and playful way while also giving everyone in the team the opportunity to contribute.



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

info@scrumteamsurvey.org

Unleashing Teams All Over The World

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Awesome content for awesome teams

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